China to the listing became glaringly apparent because the Americans made sure that four other committee members—Belgium, Germany, Poland and Equatorial Guinea—were also co-sponsors. The spotlight now shone on China as a lone holdout. This is a situation that China did not wish to see. It works hard to cultivate a certain sort of public profile, where it is seen as a responsible and constructive member of the international community.

China's earlier experiences with the listing of Masood Azhar in the 1267 Sanctions Committee had convinced China that it could indefinitely stall the Indian requests. In 2018, a well-known Chinese commentator on India–China relations had this to say about this issue: 'China can obstruct India's demands without paying nearly any price, or even needs not to give a special response.' It reflected what was, perhaps, a widely held view within the Chinese establishment that India, as a rising power, was attempting to challenge China through issues like NSG membership or the listing of Pakistan-based terrorists. The Chinese commentator's view that India had suffered a failure on account of its miscalculations of China's strengths as a major actor in the international system, did not adequately take into account that India might have learned from those initial efforts or that the global situation had changed by 2019. [8]

The final attempt to list Masood Azhar turned into a triangular bout between India, China and America. India built international support for the listing post-Pulwama while the Americans pressed the 1267 Sanctions Committee for an early listing. The Chinese understood that the listing was now only a matter of time. Therefore, this time round, the Chinese seemed to adopt a somewhat different strategy and tactics. Their limited intention was to kick the can down the road beyond the end of May, by which time it would be clear whether Prime Minister Modi would return to power or if they would be